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IT Project Management Support

Lecture 10

Managing Teams (2)

- Conflict Resolving
- Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs



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Politechnika Wrocławska

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„ZPR PWr – Zintegrowany Program Rozwoju Politechniki Wrocławskiej”

Conflict Resolving

Based on:

[https://mosaicprojects.com.au/whitepaper: Conflict Management.pdf](https://mosaicprojects.com.au/whitepaper/Conflict%20Management.pdf)

<https://proventuresindia.com/blog/conflict-management-and-its-resources-engagement/>

<https://www.leadinganswers.com/2020/07/5-tools-for-team-conflict-resolution.html>

What is conflict?

- Conflict results from incompatible goals or competition for limited resources.
- Conflict relates to differences in values, attitudes, needs, expectations, perceptions, communication styles, and personalities.
- There are a few ways to think about different types of conflicts:
 - **Interpersonal conflict** refers to a conflict between two individuals. This frequently results from differences in personality and opinion.
 - **Intragroup conflict** is a type of conflict that happens among individuals within a team.
 - **Intergroup conflict** takes place when a misunderstanding arises among different teams within an organization, often relating to competing goals and limited resources.
- Conflict may also be **manifest** (escalates quite quickly) or **latent**, caused by the inability to communicate about the source of the conflict and its impact.

7 Causes of Conflict in Project Teams

- Conflict can arise at any time during a project, leading to decreased productivity, loss of creativity and an unwillingness to collaborate. Here are common issues:

1. Project Setup

- Projects bring together individuals with various levels of experiences from different sectors. Each team member will have their own approach to project setup, methodologies, documentation, reporting and so on. Additionally, your management style can create friction within the team.

2. Communication

- Poor communication is at the root of many failed projects, so it is little surprise that communication leads to team conflict.
- Without a communication plan, team members quickly become confused about their work, priority tasks, and the overall purpose of the project.
- Differences in individual communication style also cause tension; some team members may like to record every detail using email whilst others may prefer a quick catch-up as needed.

7 Causes of Conflict in Project Teams

3. Roles and Responsibilities

- Problems quickly arise when team members do not know what they should be doing and how their work impacts others. The blame-game often starts if a key task is overlooked or delayed because no-one knew who owned the requirement.

4. Stakeholder Engagement

- Too much or too little engagement, frequent change requests, lack of internal buy-in – stakeholders can support or disrupt your project in many ways!

5. Scarce Resources

- Projects are notoriously difficult to resource, leading to competition within teams and between departments. This problem is even more troublesome in organizations that plan projects by department or without a centralized view of all projects across all teams.

7 Causes of Conflict in Project Teams

6. Underperforming team members

- Tensions will arise if some team members are not pulling their weight.

7. External vendors

- Problems with communication, deadlines, contracts, and quality can lead to disagreements with external vendors. Unresolved, these issues can lead to missed deadlines and unhappy customers.

Additional sources

- Additional sources of conflict can include team history, scope creep, schedule changes, declined change requests, and someone simply having a bad day.

Understanding the conflict

Conflict management is a key skill, particularly if you are not involved in the actual dispute, but are managing one or more of the disputants. Before you can deal with the conflict you need to understand its scope:

- What is the conflict about?
- Who is involved in the conflict? Are there ‘backers’, ‘puppet masters’ or ‘supporters’ encouraging the immediately obvious protagonists? Are there others who should be involved who are avoiding the dispute (but who are essential to the solution or will be affected by the outcome)?
- What is the root cause of the dispute?
- Why has it occurred? How has it managed to get to this stage? There has usually been a management failure.
- What is the actual or potential impact of the conflict? How much effort is sensible to expend on the dispute (expending a disproportionate amount of effort could be more detrimental than the conflict itself)?
- Are you involved you are you seeking to manage the resolution of a conflict between others? If you are involved do you need the help of an impartial third party? If you are managing a dispute between others do you have the leadership, authority or influence to make a difference to the behaviours of the disputants (or should you involve others)?

Five Levels of Conflict

The “Five Levels of Conflict” model developed by Speed Leas shows the continuum:



Five Levels of Conflict

The model starts with level one “Problem to Solve” and goes all the way up to level five “World War.”

One way to determine the level of conflict is to focus on the language the team is using and compare it to Leas's description of the five levels:

Level 1 (Problem to Solve) - The language is friendly and constructive. People use factual statements to justify their viewpoints. For example, team members may make statements such as, "Oh, I see what you are saying now. I still prefer the other approach, but I understand your suggestion."

Level 2 (Disagreement) - The language starts to include self-protection. For example, team members may make statements like, "I know you think my idea won't work as well, but we tried your approach last time, and there were a lot of problems."

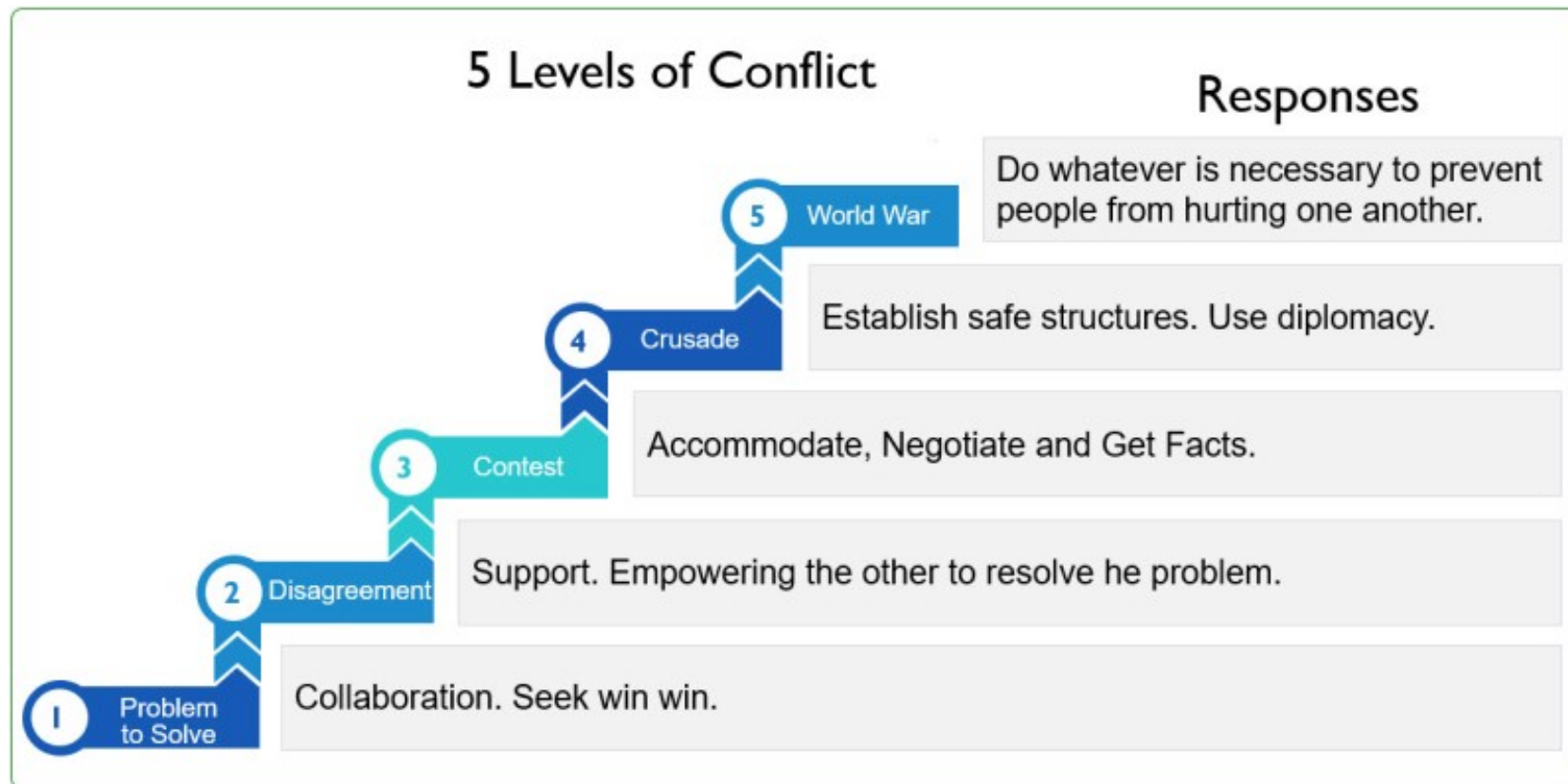
Level 3 (Contest) - The team members start using distorted language, such as over-generalizations and magnified positions (such as "He always takes over the demo" and "If only she wasn't on the team...").

Level 4 (Crusade) - The conflict becomes more ideological and polarized, such as "They're just plain wrong" and "It's not even worth talking to them."

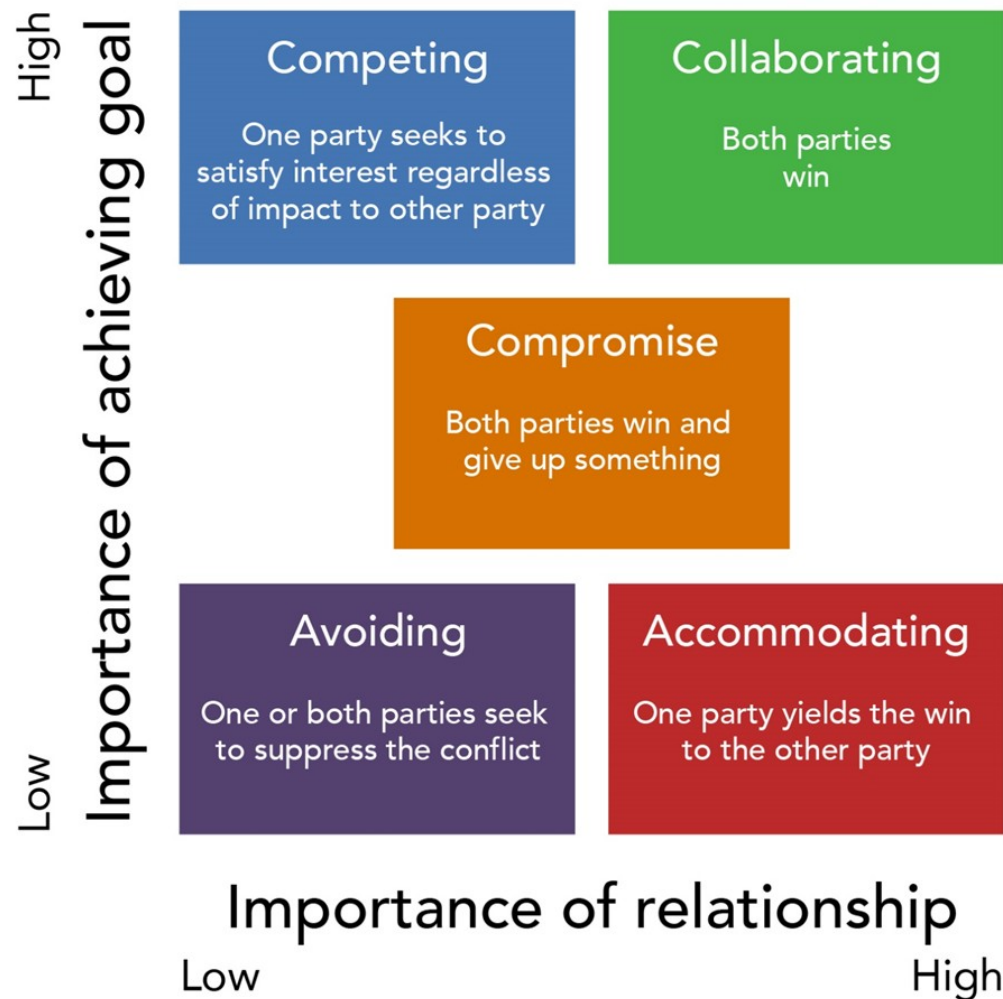
Level 5 (World War) - The language is fully combative. Opposing team members rarely speak directly to each other, instead speaking to those “on their side” and expressing sentiments like, “It’s us or them” and “We have to beat them!”

Five Levels of Conflict

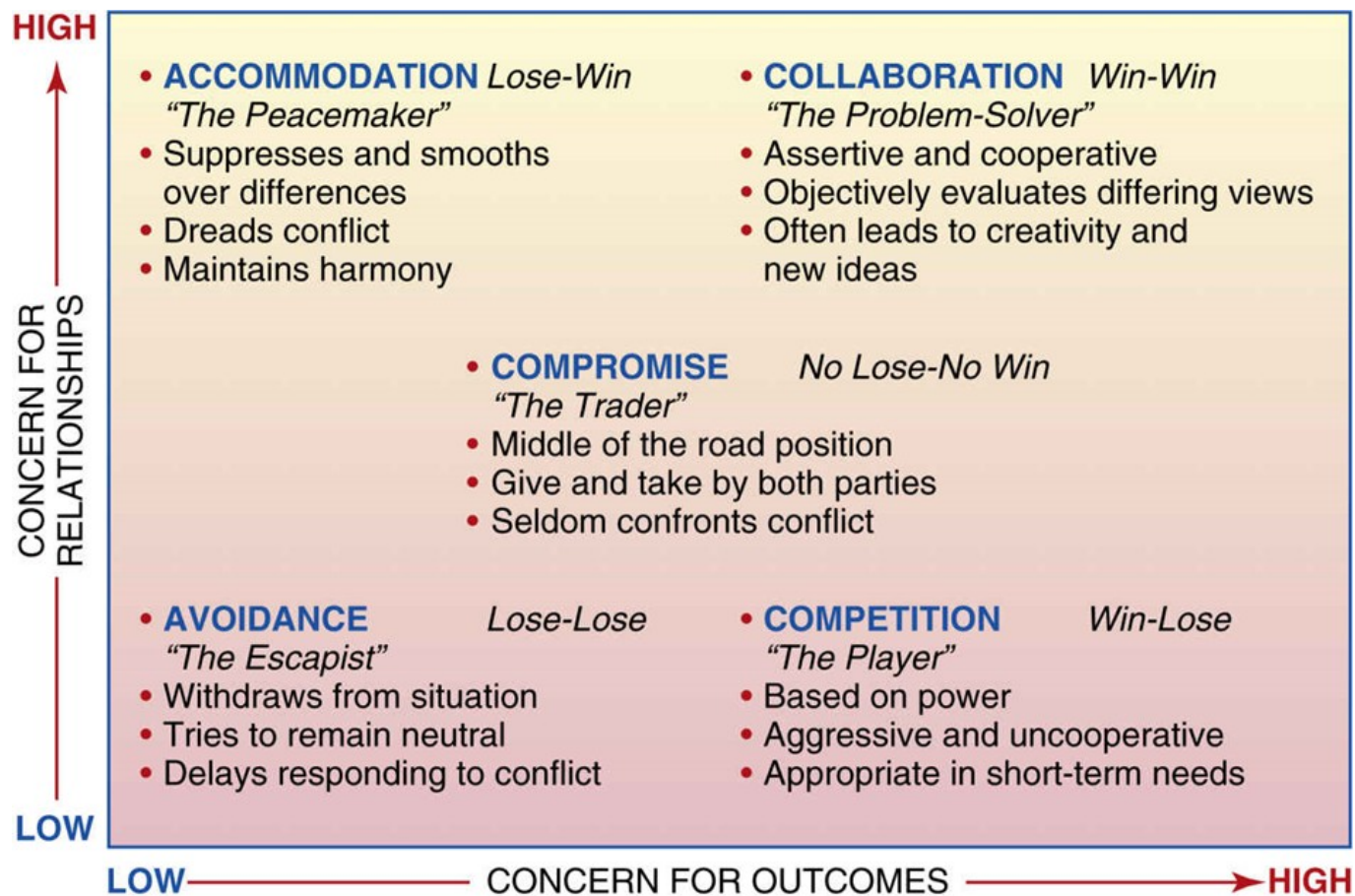
The de-escalation strategies suggested in the original Five Levels model:



5 basic strategies for resolving conflicts



5 basic strategies for resolving conflicts



5 basic strategies for resolving conflicts

Competing / Forcing / Directing (*Win – Lose*) :

- Exert your authority and positional power to insist the issue is addressed and a solution imposed.
- Typically, this is the way conflicts are resolved during an emergency where decisions are required ‘immediately’.
- However, this may only be a short term solution, as use of authority can leave one or both sides feeling disenfranchised - what seems fair and reasonable to you may not be perceived that way by the disputant.

Smoothing / Accommodating (*Lose – Win*) :

- Is not a solution but can buy time for emotions to cool and the protagonists to come to their own solution.

Compromise / Reconcile (*No lose – No win*):

- Both sides agree to give a little to resolve the dispute but this approach rarely leads to an optimal solution.

5 basic strategies for resolving conflicts

Problem solving / Collaboration (*Win – Win*) :

- Involves both sides working together to understand the other's position; recognising what might be best for any one person is not necessarily best overall or for the longer term relationships.
- Win-win negotiating requires strength of purpose.

Withdrawal / Avoidance / Acceptance (*Lose – Lose*) :

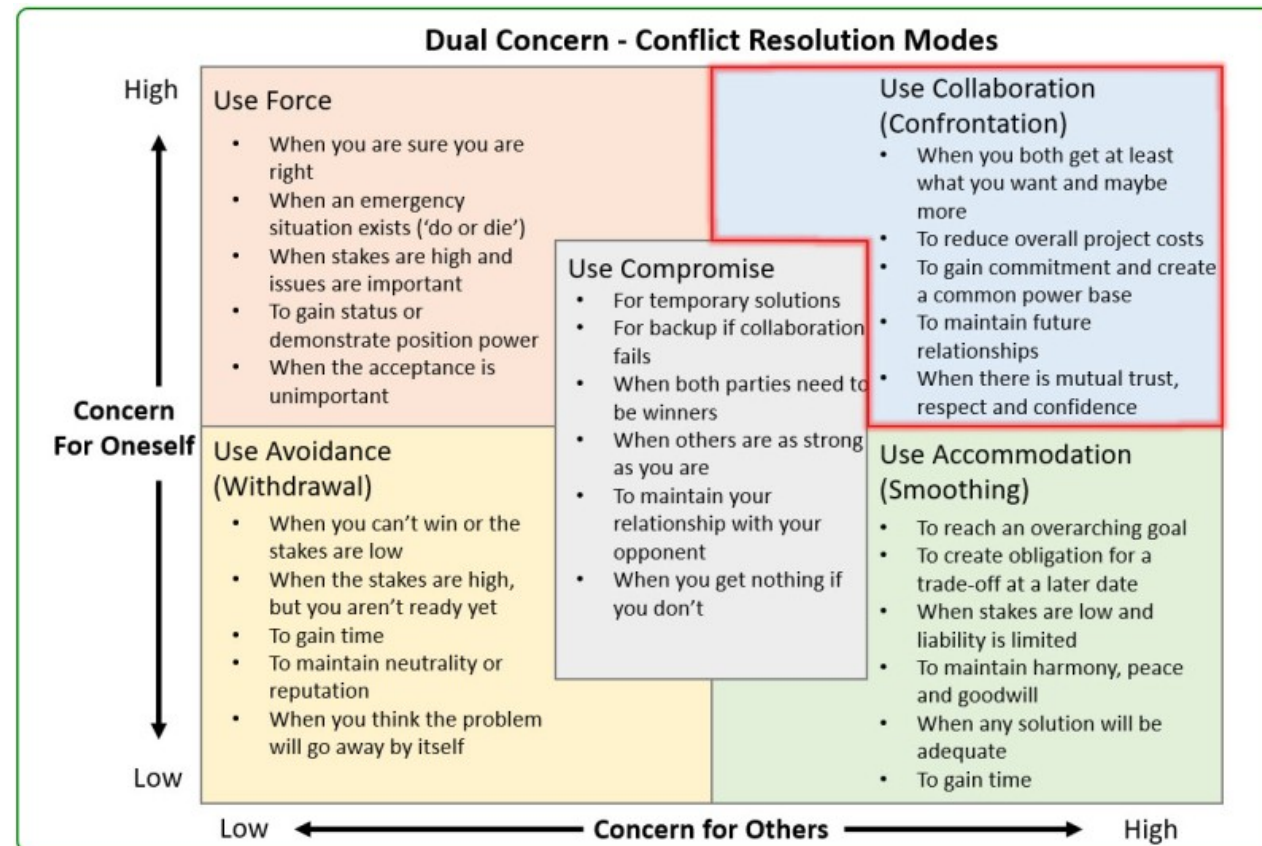
has a range of options that may be useful:.

- **Accept and settle:** Give the other party what they want. It removes the conflict at least cost but could have future ramifications⁷.
- **Accept and ignore:** The effort required to fix the problem, if it can be fixed, far outweighs the damage the conflict is doing. Accept it, move on, but watch for signs of escalation in case the impact increases
- **Delay:** Similar to 'smoothing / accommodating' to give everyone a chance to reflect on the situation. Once the heat has dissipated most problems can be rectified more easily.
- **Accommodation:** This is the path of least pain where one side accepts the other's views or position (whether or not they actually agree). But the acceptance has to be genuine to avoid a repeat of the dispute at a later date.

5 basic strategies for resolving conflicts

How we try to resolve conflict brings us to the dual-concern grid by Langton and Sadri.

This model describes conflict resolution modes plotted on an axis that shows “Concern for Ourself” (Y-axis) and “Concern for Others” (X-axis)





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Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs

Based on:

<https://pmbasics101.com/maslows-hierarchy-of-needs/>

<https://www.thoughtco.com/maslows-hierarchy-of-needs-4582571>

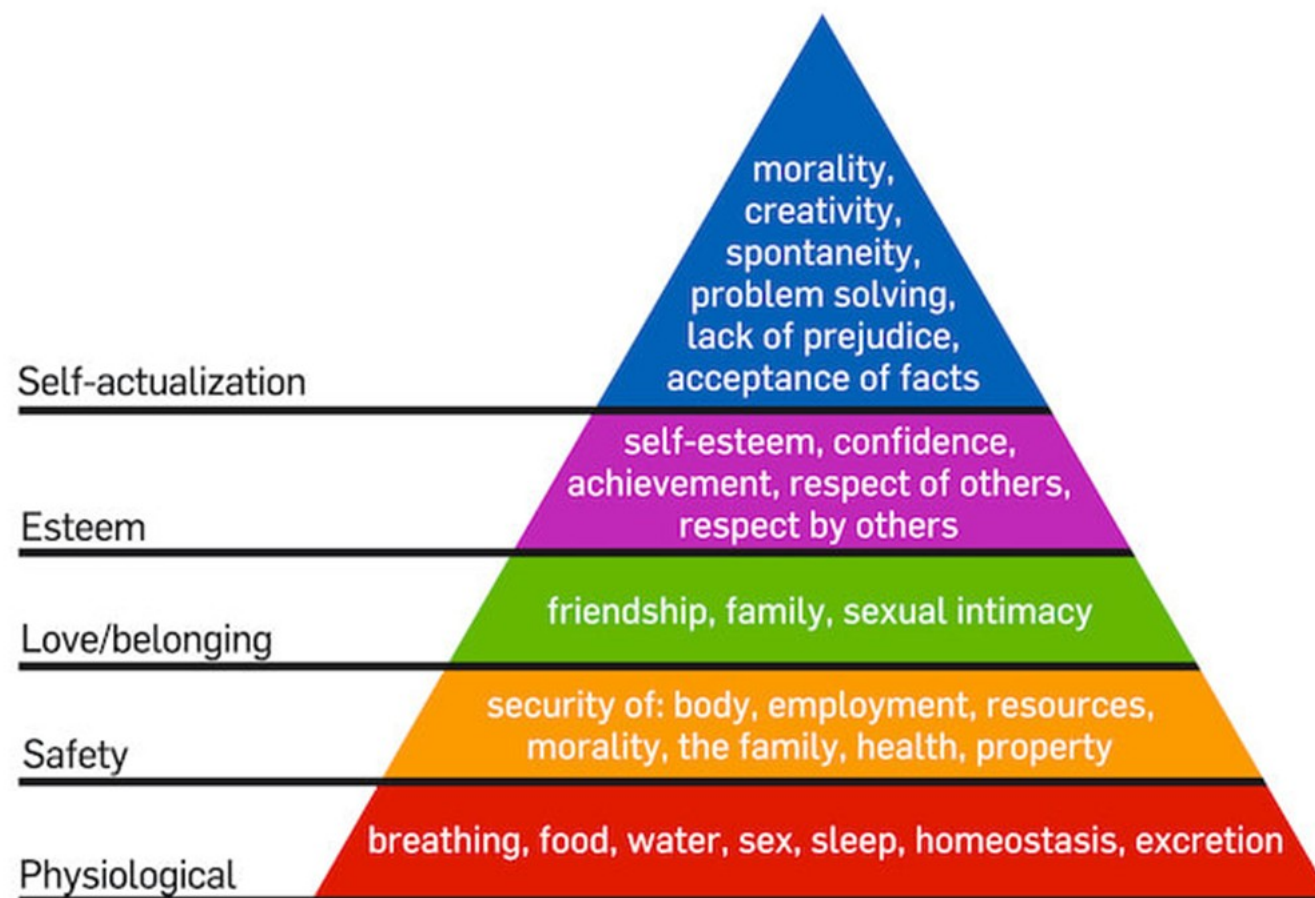
Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs

- Understanding the Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs will help you better understand how to motivate your project team.
- It's still one of the theories tested during the PMI PMP exam.
- Maslow's theory describes the pattern of how human motivation develops.
- Nowadays, the theory is represented as a pyramid.

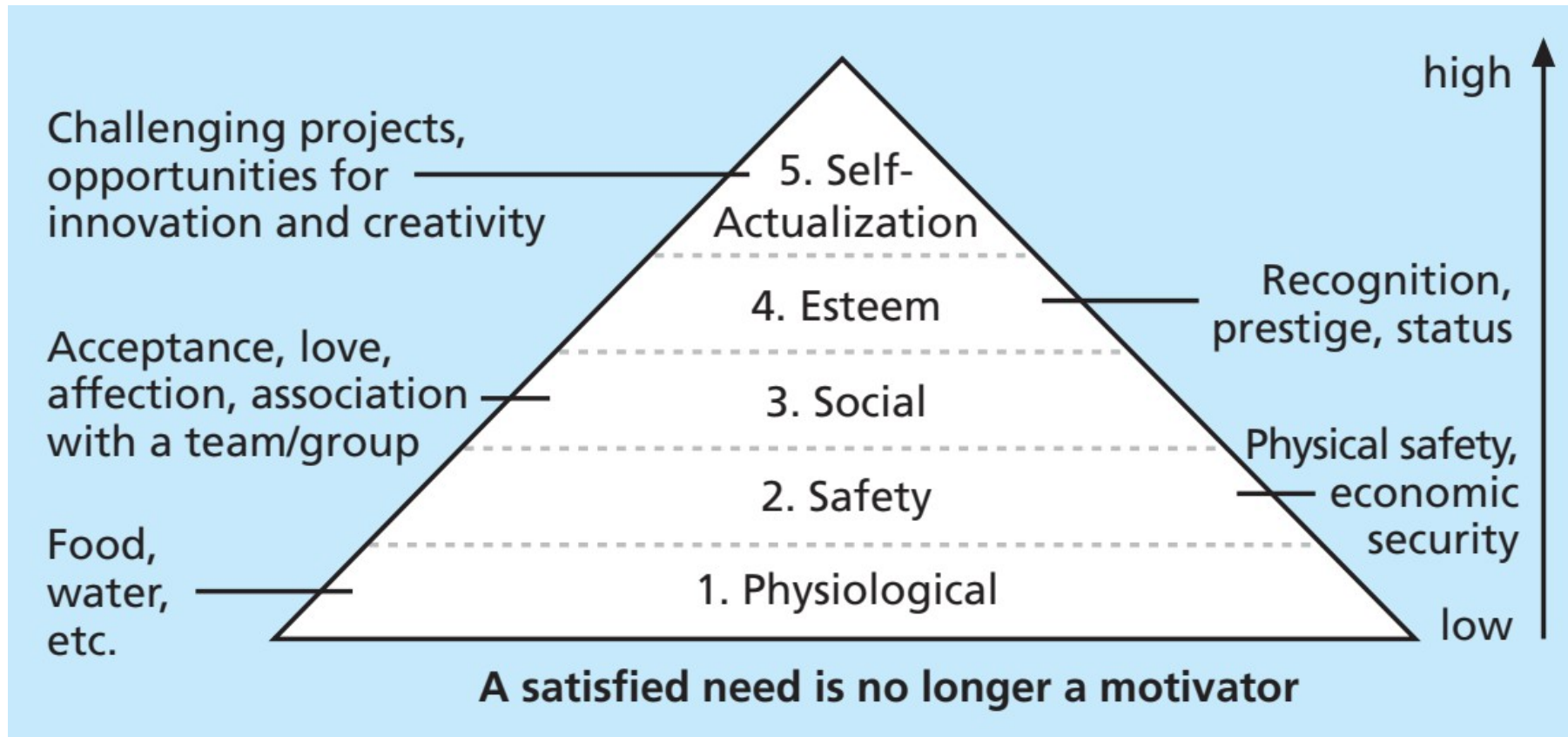


Maslow's hierarchy of needs

Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs



Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs



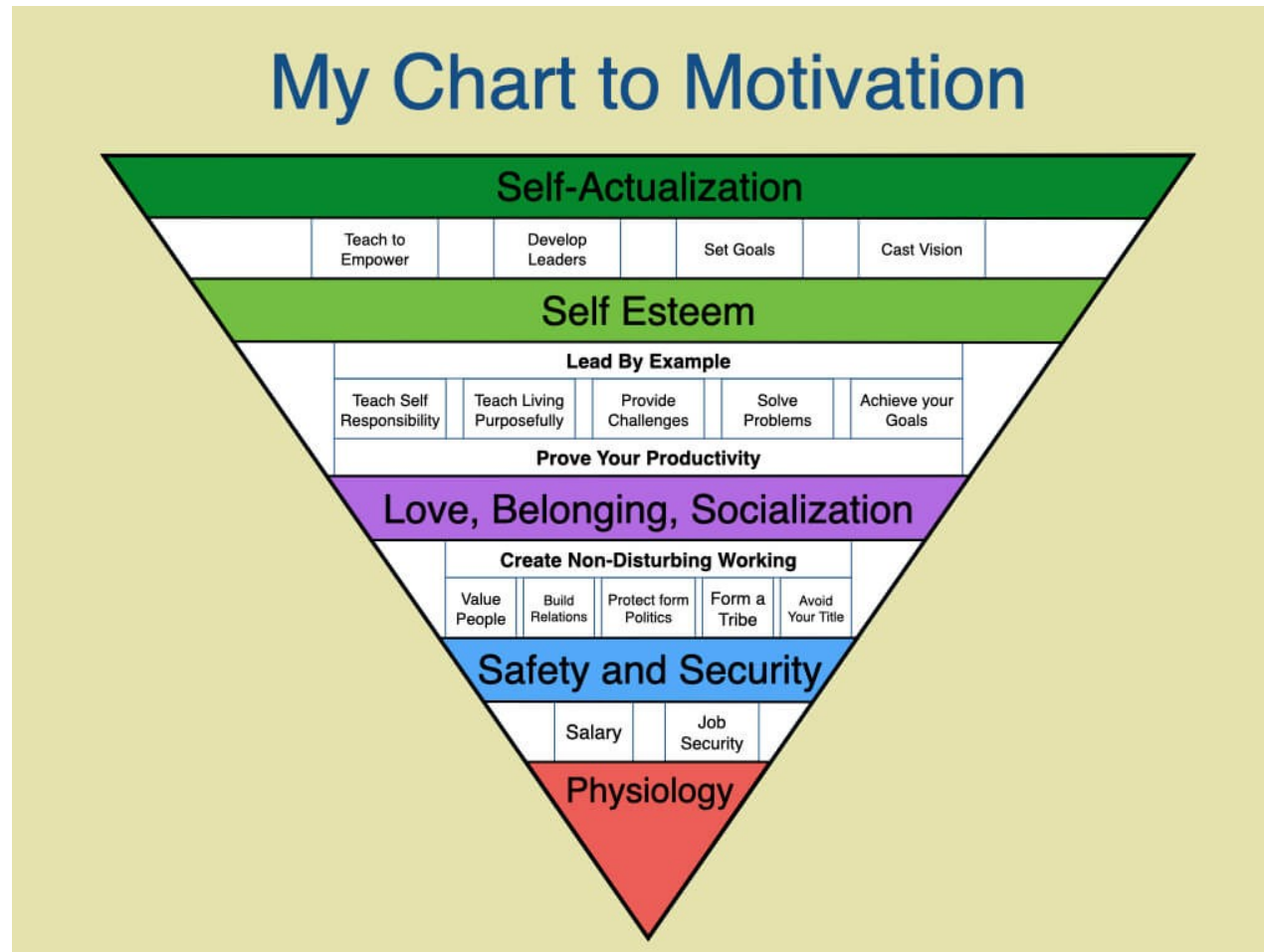
Put Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs to Work

By Dmitriy Nizhebetskiy: <https://pmbasics101.com/maslows-hierarchy-of-needs/>

- The main actionable item from the theory is this:
 - Motivational and leadership approaches and techniques from higher levels are NOT efficient when lower levels are compromised.
- In other words, you cannot improve a person's motivation on a higher level until his lower-level needs are satisfied.
- So, for example, giving additional responsibilities won't motivate a person who's struggling to put food on a table. You need to provide him with a decent salary first.
- But it will work for a person who's already looking to increase self-esteem.

Put Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs to Work

- Nizhebetzkiy's 5 Levels of Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs:



Put Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs to Work

- Our basic needs don't actually take that much space in our life.
- But on the other hand:
 - You need much more effort to motivate someone on a high-level in the hierarchy.
- So, how can you, as a project manager, use this?
- I've got five simple rules for you:

#1: Always Keep in Mind Physiological Needs

- Yeah, it sounds like you can skip it.
- You may think that you don't work in an environment with severe poverty or some disaster areas, so it is insignificant.
- But that's not true.

Modern cities and offices have transformed our physiological needs.

- Take a look around: water cooler, cakes, coffee and tea, toilets, stores with food.
- You take it for granted, that's why you don't notice it!
- However, the next time the toilet in the office is out of order or water delivery delays, do notice the amount of rumbling in the office.
- Even if people take it stoically, I do not recommend planning any team building activities.
- Most of your efforts will be wasted or inefficient.
- So, in such cases, you better focus on overcoming these small inconveniences.

Examples of Physiological Needs

- On the lowest level of needs are the things required for survival.
- These include:
 1. Air
 2. Water
 3. Food
 4. Sleep
 5. WiFi
- Anything that our body needs to operate.
- By the way, lack of good sleep is a hit on Physiological Needs.
- You'll see it with the project team members who have newborns. They won't be motivated by new challenges until they hit the bunk.

#2: Don't Undermine Safety and Security Needs

- Once you are relatively fed and warm, the safety kicks in.
- People start looking for a safe and secure shelter to sleep and live.
- They look for stability and predictability in life and at work.

Always remember that safety needs are personal.

- For example. Someone thinks we need a certain level of humidity in the office. You think it's a trivial issue. In any case, you shouldn't ignore or undermine that person's concerns.
- However, again, for most of us, this need had transformed from physical safety to financial safety.

Example of Safety Needs

- While we have a stable income, we can pay for food, rent, insurance, and able to fulfill other needs.
- Take away the money and other social securities – and the next thing your mind draws is a disturbing picture where you need to hunt your food.

That's why threats related to firing a person never motivate.

- Moreover, when you try to penalize a person, it also has a little positive effect.
- Also, delays in salary are a long-term hit on motivation because people will be afraid that payouts will be delayed next month.
- Even such a small thing as uncertainty about when the money gets to your account is a demotivator!
- Here's what you need to understand about people who already been on a higher level of the hierarchy.

Safety Needs During COVID-19

- Also, the overall stability in a country, global economic situation, bad news can all impact our need for safety and security.
- The global problems like we have today with COVID-19 require you to work closely with psychological safety needs.
- You need to address troubles and thoughts related to the safety and health of your team members.

This safety issue will be nagging people all the time.

- When people get back to offices, some of them won't be happy about it.
- Moreover, each related bad news will make a hit on motivation.
- If you'll ignore these worries, all your over motivational efforts is a waste of time.

#3: Build Up Social Belonging All The Time

- When the first two needs are met, people want to socialize.
- Your team members will want to make friends, connect with colleagues, and create families.
- It will happen with or without your participation. However, I do suggest to influence this process actively.
- For example, you can and should create a friendly and open environment.
 - Encourage professional interactions without your participation.
 - Let people network beyond the project team.
 - Ensure adequate work-life balance.
 - Make office not-for-work-only space.
 - Help to resolve conflicts.
 - Do project planning together.
 - Always help newcomers to adapt.
- Moreover, do you know this saying?

“People do not leave companies they leave managers.”

#4. Increase Team Members Esteem with Career Development Guidance

- At some point, people want to feel respected and valued.
- They want accomplishments.
- It is not easy to continuously support those feelings.
- But there are several things you can do daily without much efforts:
 - Explain the value and importance of any task that you give. Mundane tasks kill self-esteem quickly.
 - Say Thank You often. Daily.
 - Encourage people to talk about their hobbies and passions. That alone makes them proud. Never criticize or judge these activities.
 - Recognize the impact of every team member. Though be careful, not everyone feels comfortable hearing public praises.
 - Help people to set and achieve goals. The process of moving towards a challenging goal boost self-esteem better than anything.

#5. Create Environment for Self-Actualization

- But can you be of use at this level? Yes, for sure!
- Lots of team members will NOT know what they want.
- Until they understand how to realize their potential, you can help them.
- But I want you to understand that there are some problems:
 - There will be just a bit of people who's on this level. And most of the time, you'll be working on self-esteem level.
 - It usually means you need to help a person to achieve something bigger than the work on your project.
- You'll be pushing the person to prioritize something other than the work in the company.

Examples of Self Actualization Needs

- Self-actualization is personal and can be anything a person perceives valuable:
 - Career development
 - Authority
 - Family and kids
 - Sport achievements
 - Entrepreneurship
 - Creativity
 - Charity.
- Quite often, it transforms into a need to help others or to follow some higher goal or dream.



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Thank You very much
for your attention